

Draft - expert review pending

This unit is complete and passes the platform's automated checks, but no reviewer has read it yet. Treat its sources and claims with care.

Draft translation - not yet human-reviewed / مسوده ترجمه

Learning Theories

Unit 2 asked where a pupil is. This unit asks a different question: what happened when they learned? Every teacher acts on an answer, usually without noticing. The teacher who gives a star for neat work is acting on one theory of learning. The teacher who lets pupils test which objects sink is acting on another. The teacher whose class learns how to treat a wrong answer by watching how she treats the first one is acting on a third.

This unit makes those theories visible, names them, and puts them to work. It is the theory core of the course: the ideas here return in Unit 4 (cognitive processes), Unit 6 (motivation) and every unit after.

Unit learning outcomes

By the end of this unit you should be able to:

- Explain the **behaviourist** view of learning as change in observable behaviour, and describe Pavlov's classical conditioning and Skinner's operant conditioning.
- Use **reinforcement and punishment** precisely, including why negative reinforcement is not punishment, and read a classroom consequence for what it makes more or less likely.
- Explain the **cognitive turn**: learning as change in thinking, through Piaget's schemas and Bruner's representation and spiral curriculum.
- Describe **Bandura's social learning theory**: learning by observation, the conditions that strengthen it, and what the observational-learning research showed.

- Explain **constructivism** - the learner builds understanding - including Vygotsky's zone of proximal development and scaffolding.
- **Choose and combine** theories in real teaching: read one classroom episode through all four lenses and justify a teaching decision.

Prerequisite knowledge

Units 1-2 (the three-part scope; development, especially the cognitive domain that Topic 3.2 deepens). No laboratory psychology is assumed; every theory is introduced through a classroom.

In this unit

1. Topic 3.1 - Learning as behaviour: Pavlov and Skinner
2. Topic 3.2 - The cognitive turn: Piaget and Bruner
3. Topic 3.3 - Learning from others: Bandura's social learning theory
4. Topic 3.4 - Constructivist approaches and the classroom

How to use this unit

- **Work through the topics in order.** Each theory family answers the one before it: behaviourism is answered by the cognitive turn, both are widened by social learning, and constructivism assembles the whole.
- **Keep one episode in mind.** In Topic 3.1 a pupil refuses work; by Topic 3.4 you will have read that same episode four ways. The unit assessment asks for exactly that.
- **Watch your own reactions.** The theories in this unit describe teachers as much as pupils. Notice which lens you reach for first - that preference is itself data.
- After the four topics, the **unit assessment** page carries a full question bank with answers and marking guidance.

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